



**“THE CASTE SYSTEM IS LIKE
TOLSTOY’S OLD MAN, WHO
sympathises with his poor bearer
but will not get off his shoulder.”**

**SHRUTI NAGVANSHI, 34, AND LENIN
RAGHUVANSHI, 38, SOCIAL WORKERS**

It was the case of the 17-year-old Dalit bonded labourer, Nageshwar, who was being branded by a feudal landlord near Varanasi, which changed their lives. Shruti Nagvanshi, 34, and Lenin Raghuvanshi, 38, decided to fight for his cause. A year later, having rehabilitated him, they set up the People’s Vigilance Committee on Human Rights in Varanasi to work against untouchability. Raghuvanshi, a doctor, has been working with Nagvanshi, who has focused on women, children and Dalits. They have handled 350 cases and resolved 200 of them. Their resources are meagre and they rely on donations from agencies like Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and CRY. Despite this, they have managed to amplify the voice of the marginalised in national and international forums like the Peoples’ SAARC. Their work has met international recognition such as the Gwangju Human Rights Award in 2007 from the May-18 Foundation of South Korea and the ACHA Peace Star Award by the US-based Association for Communal Harmony in Asia. Married in 1992 with a 10-year-old son, the couple has six full-time dedicated staff and 30 consultants. Right now, they are focusing their attention on the struggling weavers of Varanasi, who are facing death and starvation.

by Farzand Ahmed

Role Model

Raghuvanshi’s grandfather Shanti Kumar Singh, a Gandhian freedom fighter, who used to say that grassroots politics is the future.



**“IT IS ENOUGH IF ONE
FIGHTS EVEN FOR A SMALL
cause like protecting a paddy
field. It would be a lot of help to
society and nothing can be
more fulfilling for oneself too.”**
**SUSAN THANKAPPAN, POLITICAL
ACTIVIST, 40**

**“WE CAN CHANGE
THE WORLD
ONLY THROUGH
INDIGENOUS
knowledge, not
through borrowed
ideas. Plans
and policies must
be drafted keeping
in mind the need
of the community.”**

**UTKARSH SINHA,
SOCIAL WORKER, 34**

